redemption. Because there is nothing to hold the party cadre together, they do not see politics as a collective journey.

This acrimonious organizational culture has created an unholy separation between the social and the political. All organizational work is seen as geared towards electoral success and therefore any ideological/social work is both incidental and instrumental. For example, most segments of the Congress's organization, from its students' body (the NSUI) and its youth wing to the mahila wing (women's wing) and others, are all geared towards electoral work. As a result, the Congress abandoned the social/cultural field that the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) wholly occupied. The correlation between this separation and the crisis (both electoral and ideological) that the Congress is facing lies beyond the scope of this article.

But suffice it to say that reflecting on the Gandhian strategy during the anticolonial struggle will offer a sharp contrast. M.K. Gandhi had the unenviable task of transforming social hierarchies and discrimination within while forging the same contending social groups into a collective against the British. Gandhi devised a two-pronged strategy of 'constructive work' and 'political work'. The constructive work consisted of social work based on mutuality and cooperation to negotiate questions of caste, class and gender. For instance, to deal with class inequalities, Gandhi suggested the principle of trusteeship, where the wealthy are the custodians and not owners of the wealth. To deal with caste, Gandhi took up the task of spiritualizing menial caste occupations that caste Hindus should feel grateful and obliged for. On the other hand, political work was directly aimed against the British based on civil disobedience and non-cooperation. Without personalizing the struggle against a viceroy or a governor (unlike what the Congress does today), this strategy worked well as part of the anticolonial struggle.

But post-Independence, the Congress party seems to have been severely afflicted by this separation between the constructive and political. Its self-inflicted wound ensured it could no longer complement its political/electoral strategies with social/cultural mobilizations. This was